

Barbizon School

After Constable's paintings won a gold medal at the 1824 Paris Salon, his large landscapes and open-air oil sketches inspired a group of young French artists who began painting in the village of Barbizon near the Forest of Fontainebleau. Expressing romantic views of nature, they usually sketched outdoors but completed paintings in their studios. They became known for their loose brushwork, patches of unblended colour and light-reflecting tones; in making landscape an independent subject, they were important precursors to Realism and Impressionism.

Artists of the Barbizon School included Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot (1796–1875), Jean-François Millet, Theodore Rousseau (1812–67) and others. Rousseau's direct applications of small, highly textured brushstrokes presaged the Impressionists. After travelling in Italy and France, Corot's paintings and oil sketches were clearly defined and fresh, using bright colours in fluid strokes, but from the 1850s, his style became softer, his palette reduced and his landscapes atmospheric.



Corot, *Landscape near Riva on Lake Garda*, 1835